

Quest Book Illustrious Order of the Red Cross

ILLUSTRIOUS ORDER OF THE RED CROSS

--- HISTORICAL ---

The Illustrious Order of the Red Cross is among the oldest degrees in Masonry and the message it conveys is considered so important that the degree appears in or is mentioned in the degree work of several other bodies. Some of those bodies include the Allied Masonic Degrees in England, Royal Order of Scotland, Order of Knight Masons, Ultimate of Irish Freemasonry, Scottish Rite and the Elect Cohens of the Universe of Martinez de Pasqually.

How and where the order actually came into existence is not known, but there are some tantalizing clues. Most scholars agree that the degree was first conferred in the American Colonies by Scottish or Irish troops of the British Army in the latter part of the 18th century. However, some believe it was conferred upon Benjamin Hurd Jr., a merchant from Boston, during his travels to Europe. Hurd organized the “Council of Red Cross Knights” in Boston and began conferring the order. The earliest written records of the Order of the Red Cross are the “Beaumont” diploma issued by South Carolina Encampment #1 on August 1, 1783 and a certificate issued by the Encampment at Newburyport, Massachusetts to Hamilton Moore on February 16, 1796.

Thomas Smith-Webb and Henry Fowle are seen as the driving force behind the spread of the Order throughout New England. It was mainly because of their influence that the Order was adopted by the General Grand Encampment (the forerunner of our Grand Encampment) and became part of the Templar system we know today.

This does not mean that there was not a lot of controversy surrounding the Illustrious Order of the Red Cross. There were two points at the center of this controversy: first that the Red Cross was not a Christian order (calling it a Pagan and Jewish Rite) and therefore should not be included in the system; and the second being that the Order was not included in the systems of foreign (British system) jurisdiction. Therefore to maintain standardization, the Red Cross should not be included. This controversy raged through the 19th century and many attempts were made to remove the Order from our system. However the controversy was ended when the Illustrious Order of the Red Cross was adopted by the Grand Encampment, in Denver, on August 10, 1892.

--- SYMBOLS ---

The Illustrious Order of the Red Cross is replete with symbolism and in the discussions below we will only scratch the surface. Therefore it is your task to continue researching and find your own interpretation and “truth” within the IORC.

Jewish Council: In the IORC the Jewish Council is symbolic of, or represents the Sanhedrin. The ancient Jewish court system was called the Sanhedrin and was an assembly of twenty-three to seventy-one men (elders) appointed in every city in the Land of Israel. The Great Sanhedrin (which we see here) was the supreme religious body in the Land of Israel during the time of the

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Holy Temple. The earliest record of a Sanhedrin is recorded by Josephus and was convened in 57BC. The Sanhedrin's existed until the system was abolished in 425 AD.

The King: Historically, this is probably the court of King Darius I (the Great) known for his administrative genius, and massive building projects, but we are not told that. This was probably done intentional so that the king remains mysterious, thus better suited to the authors purpose. If the king remains mysterious we are not bound by the facts and figures of his reign, improving our ability to apply the symbolism intended by the author. As the story unfolds we learn that Zerubbabel was the bodyguard and friend to Darius. We also learn that Darius, not a Jew, did believe in the one true God and vowed that if he became king he would rebuild the city of Jerusalem and restore the Temple of God.

The Green Sash: As the High Priest and King informed you, the Green Sash is to perpetuate the remembrance of events, renewal of our friendship, and to inculcate the almighty force and the importance of TRUTH. Its color should ever remind you that **truth** is a divine attribute and the foundation of every virtue. That being said, let us look at the Green Sash. The sash is a bright forest green with a blood red passion cross superimposed upon its surface. The color green is symbolic of many things but in this case, joined with the red passion cross, it is symbolic of immortality, resurrection, renewal and rebirth. Like the green, red symbolizes many things but in this case the red passion cross is symbolic of blood and death. The cross was a device used by the Romans to torture and kill enemies of the State and therefore a symbol of death. To the Christian knight the combination of the device and colors allude to death and resurrection of Christ. So as you can see, the meaning of the Green Sash goes far beyond the short reminder provided by the High Priest and the King.

The Sword: On presenting you with the sword the High Priest and King informed you that it is endowed with three excellent qualities: its hilt, with Faith; its blade, with Hope; and its point with Charity. It is to remain in its scabbard, only to be drawn in a just cause.

Zerubbabel: The candidate of the IORC was, in the biblical account, a prince and governor of the Jews in Persia and grandson of Jehoiachin the last king of Judah before the fall. Zerubbabel led the first group of Jews on their return from the Babylonian captivity in the first year of the reign of King Cyrus of Persia. This was between the years of 538 and 520 BC. Zerubbabel is not a Hebrew word or name but a contraction of Assyrian-Babylonian words that mean "Seed of Babylon" or conceived in Babylon.

The Jewish Banner: The Banner of Judah is a white field (background) with a Lion Rampant in gold. White is associated with light, goodness, innocence, purity, and virginity. It is considered to be the color of perfection. White means safety, purity, and cleanliness. As opposed to black, white usually has a positive connotation. The color gold is cousin to the color yellow and is also associated with illumination, love, compassion, courage, passion, magic, and wisdom. Gold is a precious metal that is associated with wealth, grandeur, and prosperity, (a king and his kingdom) as well as sparkle, glitz, glamour and glory. The rampant lion of power, authority, in motion, flourishing or spreading unchecked.

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The Persian Banner: A white field, a blazing sun in the upper half and three crescent (half) moons in the lower half all in gold. The meaning of white and gold are the same as above. The sun and moon represent transition and the cycle of day and night, life and death, above and below. The tree moons represent the cycle of life.

The Bridge: Bridges are links between two places, they allow you to overcome obstacles, to reach your destination. Therefore they symbolize transition, a change and success, crossing over to something new or to a new place. Rivers often represent life and the passage of life and time. One interpretation is that together they represent the crossing from life over the bridge of death to eternal life. There are many other interpretations as well.

The Banner of the Illustrious Order of the Red Cross (IORC): The Banner of the IORC is green with a 7-pointed star at its center. Within the star is a golden ring with the motto: "Magna est veritas, et praevalere bit" (Great is truth and it will prevail). Within the golden ring is a white circular field with a red Greek cross upon it. On each of the four arms is a letter which represents Deity, Truth, Justice, and Liberty. These will commemorate our faith in God and in the Grand Characteristics of this Illustrious Order. The green seven-pointed star may also represent the seven gifts of the Spirit - wisdom, understanding, counsel, might, knowledge, fear of the Lord, and delight in the Lord. The green field (the background) and the star representing life, everlasting life, and resurrection as stated above in the green sash. The circle of gold surrounding a white circle may represent the God of the Old Testament surrounding the purity (white circle), life and death, (the red cross), of the Messiah within the New Testament.

--- LESSON OF THE ORDER ---

Unlike the other chivalric orders within the Commandery system, the Illustrious Order of the Red Cross contains nothing of a Christian nature. It does however form the bridge between the teaching of Old Testament and the New Testament of the Bible. At the same time and in the same way it transitions each of us from the non-denominational Ancient Craft Masonry to Chivalric Masonry. It reminds us that the lesson of truth binds the legend of Hiram to the teachings of Christ, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life." The theme upon which this Order is based has biblical roots, for it is based upon an account found in the book of II Esdras in the Apocrapha and in the writings of (the Roman historian) Josephus. It teaches reliance upon the inherent values of reverence for Deity, truth, justice and liberty, with the emphasis being placed on the importance of truth.

The IORC is a three act play who's setting moves from Jerusalem to Babylon and back. It is one of few degrees in the York Rite system that falls in its proper sequence as it chronologically follows the Super Excellent Master's Degree, occurring at the end of the Babylonian Captivity.

As Act I opens we find ourselves observing arguments within the Jewish Council, the Sanhedrin, ruling council of the city of Jerusalem, headed by the High Priest. The members are lamenting the plight of the city and arguing the wisdom of Zerubbabel's journey. Zerubbabel has offered to go to King Darius, whom Zerubbabel knows well having served him as a bodyguard, and remind

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the King of the vow he made, to rebuild the city of Jerusalem and restore the Temple of God. The Council debates the wisdom of this venture and in the end it is agreed that Zerubbabel (Truth) should represent the Council because he is strong of character and being well known to the King.

The journey, Act II, Prince Zerubbabel takes a trek through dangerous territory filled with bandits, robbers, and many hazards. A journey of between 880 and 1,600 miles (depending on your route) through the wilderness of both Judea and Persia (currently the countries of Israel, Syria, Jordan and Iraq) which would take several months by camel.

On his journey Zerubbabel crossed deserts and rivers, over bridges and through storms. There is much symbolism here and it may be the most important part of the Order. His journey, in many ways, mimics our journey through life and death on our way to the afterlife. The two lands represent the conscious and the subconscious mind as well as the land of the living and the land of the dead. Upon crossing the bridge into Persian territory Zerubbabel is detected as an intruder, captured and taken as a prisoner to the court of King Darius.

In Act III Zerubbabel is brought to the court of the mysterious King. Upon gaining his audience with the King, Zerubbabel is recognized because he is well known to the King. Zerubbabel explains that he is there on behalf of his people. The King, in a clever ruse, tests Zerubbabel to determine if he understands the importance of silence and secrecy. On demonstrating his courage, strength of character and that he truly does understand the importance of keeping silent on secret matters the King welcomes Zerubbabel as a friend and makes him a member of his household.

Act III continues with the King and his councilors, as is their usual custom, discussing a question posed by the King. Zerubbabel is invited to join the Immemorial Discussion. The discussion is about strength and who possesses it. Zerubbabel is given the task of arguing one of the topics, which he does successfully, and thinking outside the box he adds that *truth* is in fact the strongest. Impressed with Zerubbabel's answer the King inquires of Zerubbabel what reward he seeks. Zerubbabel requests that the King fulfill his vow of restoring the Temple. The mysterious King fulfills this vow and grants Zerubbabel a passport which will insure safe passage between the realms. This is important, because this is no small gift, it allows Zerubbabel (Truth) to pass, unhindered, between the realms of the conscious and subconscious mind, the lands of the living and the dead. Granting him the ability to come and go, learning more as needed.
